COMP 3700A: Contributing to Open Source

Funding Open Source

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Topic Overview

- Why FOSS needs funding
- How projects are funded
- How individuals are funded

Free as in freedom, not as in beer

Four essential freedoms, according to the Free Software Foundation:

0. **Run** the program as you wish
1. **Study** and **change** the program
2. **Redistribute copies**
3. Distribute your **modified versions**

> *The Open Source Definition is somewhat looser, but essentially the same*
>
> *"Free" does not refer to cost!*

Why does FOSS need funding?

- Pretty much every software system depends on FOSS
- Systems come with costs:
  - servers
  - domain names
  - compute
  - And the big one: the people!

> *What happens when one maintainer decides to rage quit?*

More examples

- The end of the curl bug bounty program
- Holding core-js "hostage"
- This community-sourced list of underfunded projects
- For javascript projects, try running `npm fund` to see which of your dependencies are begging for funds!

Project funding: find some examples

- Government/nonprofit grants
- Corporate sponsorship
- Support agreements
- Donations (BuyMeACoffee, Paypal, Patreon, OpenCollective, etc)
- Something else?



How are projects funded?

Share your examples

Individual funding: find some examples

Some overlap with previous list, but also:

- Developer programs (e.g. Outreachy, GSoC)
- Bug bounty programs
- Contribute to FOSS on company time
- Contracts from projects with funding
- Something else?



How are individuals funded?

Share your examples

Coming up next

- Midterm review, including what to expect on format, number of questions, etc
- Homework question: tell me your midterm concerns